Planning for Teaching and Practicing

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching*, 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024), 188-199; 136-144.

Intuitively we all know that planning is a good idea, but often the problem is having the time to plan—or failing to plan to make time! Although planning is time consuming and initially hard work, the benefits are many. A season plan is your road map to ensure that you will teach all that needs to be learned—not only the obviously required technical skills and physical training but also the tactical and mental skills that are essential for success. A season plan helps you to keep on track and sort out what's important. It also pays off over the course of many seasons because your plan is a framework for evaluating past seasons and developing a better plan for the next season. Think of planning as an investment: It pays big dividends in future time saved.

Through planning, you are far more likely to do the following:

- Keep your athletes actively involved, resulting in more learning and enjoyment during practices
- Provide challenging and relevant learning situations
- Teach skills in the appropriate progression to maximize learning and safety
- Pace the learning and conditioning so your athletes are not overloaded or overtrained
- Make the best use of available time, space, equipment, and assistant coaches

Now that you appreciate the value of planning, let's go through the five-step process to effective instruction planning, as shown in figure 12.1. If you work through each of the five steps during your forthcoming season, you'll provide more effective instruction than you have in the past.

FIGURE 12.1 Five steps of instruction planning.

Step	Instruction-planning stage
1	Identify the skills your athletes need
2	Know your athletes
3	Analyze your situation
4	Establish priorities
5	Plan practices

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Step 1: Identify the Skills Your Athletes Need

To be effective, an instruction plan should address four categories of skills—technical, tactical, physical, and mental.

Identifying Skills

Sources for Identifying Skills

How do you identify the subject matter you will teach? Here are the major sources:

1. Draw on your experiences as a coach and athlete to identify the skills you believe are essential.
2. Search the Internet, read books, and watch videos for ideas about teaching skills in your sport. See Human Kinetics' many resources for your sport: https://us.humankinetics.com/.
3. Attend clinics or courses sponsored by sport organizations and master coaches. Contact your national sport organization or search online for courses and information.
4. Consult more experienced coaches and athletes in your area, asking them to share with you the various skills they teach and how they teach them. Visit the practices of these coaches to observe how they teach and organize.
5. Become a keen observer of the sport. As you watch the sport in person or on television, closely observe essential skills.

Next, we look at some suggestions on how to identify technical, tactical, physical, and mental skills.

Technical Skills

First, identify the basic or core skills that every player must possess to play the sport at your level of competition. Your athletes will likely possess these core skills to varying degrees. All sports require that athletes perform the fundamentals well, so you'll want to help your athletes develop these skills further and keep them sharp throughout the season. For your sport, consider the skills of each position, or each event, and for various situations in the contest. See figure 12.2 for an example of technical skills to be taught for a high school basketball team.

If you're really serious about coaching as a career, you should develop a system to catalog information about teaching the technical skills in your sport. One system is to create a hard copy or electronic folder for each skill, inserting a form such as form 12.1, and then filing articles along with the form in the folder. The forms would be a great resource for you to consult each season.

Tactical Skills

Along with planning to teach technical skills, your sport may require that you teach offensive and defensive systems as well. Figure 12.3 provides an example of team tactical

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systems for a high school basketball team. You can create a calendar to chart the progression of teaching these systems to your team. For example, you may need only one player and one zone offense prior to your first game. The others can be learned as the season progresses. However, some systems should be in place by the first game, such as how to break a press and some basic in-bounds plays.

FIGURE 12.2 Technical Skills for a High School Basketball Team

CORE SKILLS FOR ALL PLAYERS

- Passing and receiving passes: bounce pass and chest pass
- Shooting: outside jump shot, pull-up jump shot, layup (both hands), free throw
- Movement and screening: V-cuts, back cuts, on-ball, off-ball
- Rebounding: positioning, boxing out
- Dribbling: right and left hand with head up
- Defense: stance and movement; post, perimeter, and open court

CORE SKILLS FOR SPECIFIC POSITIONS

Post Players

- Turnaround jump shots, bank shots, and layups with both hands
- Pivot, drop step, step through
- Screen and roll, up-screens, down-screens
- Shot fakes (pump and power up with both hands)
- Defensive position and footwork on the low and high post

Perimeter Players

- Crossover, reverse, hesitation, and change-of-pace dribbles
- Pass or shoot off the dribble
- Catch and shoot
- Forcing dribbler to use weak hand and to pick up dribble

ADVANCED SKILLS BY POSITION

Post Players

- Outlet passes: two-hand overhead pass and baseball pass
- Fill the lane: handles pass for layup or jump shot
- Hook shots and reverse layups
- Shot blocks

Perimeter Players

- Fakes to drive, pass, or dribble
- Three-point shots: around arc on the catch and off the dribble
- Behind-the-back dribble and between-the-legs dribble
- Fight through and over the top of screens

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching,* 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024).

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FORM 12.1

Technical Skill Instruction Form

Skill name:

Position (if any):

Skill type: ☐ Core ☐ Offensive ☐ Advanced ☐ Defensive

Skill description:

Key teaching points:

Common errors and how to correct:

References:

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching,* 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024).

FIGURE 12.3 Team Tactical Systems for High School Basketball

OFFENSE

a. Player Offenses
    1. Dribble drive motion
    2. Flex
    3. 1-3-1 cutters
b. Zone Offenses
    1. Yo-yo

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2. Motion

c. Special Offensive Situations
    1. Fast break and transition
    2. Press breaker (against zone press)
    3. Press breaker (against player press)
    4. In-bounds plays
d. Basic Offensive Principles
    1. Pick and roll; give and go
    2. Screens: back, down, cross, ball
    3. Balancing the floor

DEFENSE

a. Player
b. 2-3 Zone
c. Presses
    1. Player press
    2. Zone press
d. Basic Defensive Principles
    1. Ball-you-player
    2. Strong and help sides

OTHER

a. Jump Balls
b. Free-Throw Positioning and Box-Out Responsibilities

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching,* 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024).

For whatever sport you coach, it is essential to identify any team tactics or systems that your athletes need to learn.

High school basketball coach Mike Jones explains his planning for team tactical systems (USA Basketball, 2019, para. 4):

> *We have a template that we use each preseason to map out what we want to do in practice for the entire season for each month. For example, we want to have our core defensive principles, full-court press, [player] offense, a zone offense vs. even and odd front, a press break, and four out-of-bounds plays put in before December 1 each season. How detailed we are and how much we will put in varies depending on the experience and basketball IQ of our team.*

Along with the team tactics or systems, the teaching of individual tactical skills must also be included in your planning. You'll find help in teaching tactical skills in Human Kinetics' *Coaching [Sport] Technical and Tactical Skills* ebooks and online courses.

More and more examples of teaching tactics are available on the Internet. Type in "teaching individual tactics in [sport]," and you can find many sources. For example, the search term "13 key tennis singles strategies and tactics" includes such tips as keep hitting at your opponent's backhand, stand diagonally opposite to your opponent, move in to the net when your opponent is under pressure, and angle your shots when at the net (Goodman, 2021). A similar site provides tactical tennis strategies with specific drills that can be used for each tactic (TennisGate, 2021). As an example, for the tactic of using a variety of shots (spin, depth, height, direction, or speed) to create errors or short balls, the drill "Never the Same" can be used. In this drill, players are not allowed to hit the same type of shot twice in a row during a point.

Physical Conditioning Skills

Along with technical and tactical skills, your athletes must gain the physical conditioning to support their performance. Although conditioning is not always appreciated as a skill, it definitely qualifies. Athletes must learn proper techniques to perform exercises, athletic movement activities, and drills correctly and the discipline needed to adhere to them to progress their training effectively and safely. As coach, it is your responsibility, perhaps in consultation with a strength and conditioning specialist, to determine what types and how much training are needed in your sport situation (e.g., strength, speed, power, endurance, flexibility). The basics of physical training are explained in part IV of the book. In addition, specific physical training strategies for various sports may be found online. You could also seek out a strength and conditioning specialist if there is no such professional employed in your organization. The National Strength and Conditioning Association (NSCA) sponsors a training program to certify individuals as Certified Strength and Conditioning Specialists (CSCS). It would be advisable to know the credentials of the person you choose to help train your athletes.

Mental Skills

Although most coaches recognize the importance of mental skills for athletes, they often are unsure about how to train these important skills. Coaches tell athletes things like, "You need to focus out there," but they fail to train them in some basic focusing strategies. Athletes are also expected to manage their emotions, particularly anxiety and anger, but these are skills that need to be taught and practiced.

To be a successful coach, you should learn how to teach the basic mental skills needed for your sport. Books written specifically for coaches about how to train mental skills in athletes are also available (e.g., Gilbert, 2017; Vealey, 2022). Some simple mental tools such as imagery (visualization), breathing (for physical relaxation), and productive self-talk strategies can be taught to athletes to build their mental skills, and these techniques can be easily incorporated into practice in brief and useful ways.

To teach mental skills to your athletes, you may prefer to seek out mental performance consultants, sometimes called mental coaches or even sport psychologists (the latter

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meaning they are licensed psychologists). Consider their training and ask if they are a Certified Mental Performance Consultant (CMPC), which means that they have attained education and mentored training as part of a nationally accredited program.

Whether or not you seek out a consultant, you as the coach will still be your team's mental skills coach on a day-to-day basis. How you demonstrate these mental skills, how you respond under pressure, and how you motivate and provide feedback to your athletes will influence their development of mental skills.



Coaching includes teaching mental skills, such as focus and managing emotions.

Tim Macpherson/Image Source/Getty Images

Additional Skills to Teach Athletes

Typically coaches don't consider ways in which they can teach communication, motivation, and character skills, which were discussed in part II of this book. These skills can and should be taught, and they can be explicitly incorporated into your planning for teaching. How athletes communicate with their fellow teammates plays a huge role in determining the performance of the team. Athletes who can demonstrate listening skills, resolve conflict, and express themselves productively are better positioned to be successful. Athletes at some levels need to learn to communicate with the public, especially with the media when being interviewed and when speaking to groups.

Teaching Athletes Productive Self-Talk: An Example

Self-talk is what athletes think about—what they say to themselves out loud or in their heads. Consider how you could incorporate some simple self-talk training in your practices and competitive routines to help athletes think better. Here's a real-life example (Hatzigeorgiadis et al., 2014).

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Teaching Athletes Productive Self-Talk: An Example *(continued)*

Competitive teenage swimmers were introduced to the mental tool of self-talk, and practiced effective self-talk under supervision 3 times per week for 10 weeks. The interventions were individually planned for each swimmer and were practiced in their main swimming set each practice. They were trained in which cue words to use and when and how to use them. A card with the self-talk cues was placed in each swimmer's lane just before they started their main swimming set. The following table features some examples:

Type	Cue	When	Purpose
Motivational self-talk	"Power legs"	During push after turns	To boost effort
Instructional self-talk: freestyle	"Elbow"	On releasing arm for recovery	To keep elbow high
Instructional self-talk: backstroke	"Deep"	When entering arm in water	To get arm deep for catch

The swimmers repeatedly identified the cues that were most helpful to them, and their cues cards were updated. Each swimmer also developed a self-talk competition plan, which involved planning how and what to think at various times before and during competitive events. The swimmers in the intervention (self-talk) group had greater performance improvements than swimmers in the control group (which didn't engage in the self-talk training program).

Team-building exercises that emphasize communication can be incorporated into your planning. You could require one athlete to identify a quotation for each practice day, and at the beginning of practice, explain the quotation and how the team can benefit from the idea expressed in it. This quotation could be about motivation or character. There may be certain aspects of communication and behavior that you expect of your athletes, such as maintaining eye contact with coaches and teammates when speaking, or talking productively at all times (no negativity or complaining). A good idea is to lead the team in a discussion of what culture they wish to have, including behavioral and communication specifics for all athletes to contribute to the desired culture (e.g., promptness, responding to criticism). We have found when athletes are part of the culture-building process, they are much more committed to being productive culture-keepers.

Creating a List of the Skills You'll Teach

It may be useful for you to create either one large list or separate, smaller lists for the technical, tactical, physical, and mental skills that you feel are important to be developed in your athletes. These should be the very specific skills important for athletes' success, and the lists could differ by position. For example, your goalkeepers in soccer would

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have different technical, tactical, and perhaps even mental skills as compared to your other players.

These lists will remind you of what to teach (and spur you into developing ways to teach each skill as well). You could also add a rating scale to each skill if you would like to provide ongoing evaluation and feedback to your athletes.

Step 2: Know Your Athletes

In planning what you will teach to your athletes, you must consider their prior knowledge and any characteristics about them that may determine what and how much they can learn. As you prepare your instruction plan, you will want to have answers to the following questions:

- How old are your athletes, and what is their level of physical, psychological, and social maturity?
- How much experience in the sport do your athletes have, and how wide is that range of experience?
- How well do your athletes know each other, and how well do they work together in groups?
- How well do your athletes accept responsibilities?
- What are your athletes' present skills in the categories of skills that you have deemed important for them?
- What are your athletes' capabilities in developing these skills?

Although you may know some or most of your team members well from coaching them in previous seasons, it's beneficial to systematically evaluate your players on skills you've identified as important. Here are four reasons for conducting preseason evaluations:

1. It helps you establish each athlete's entry level or starting point for instruction, and thus helps personalize instruction to maximize learning and early success.
2. It helps you assess the improvement your athletes have made over the course of the season.
3. You may not be able to keep everyone who would like to play on the team. Initial evaluation is a way to select the athletes you wish to keep.
4. You can match your athletes by their skills and knowledge and thus organize safe and equitable practice games.

You can conduct preseason evaluations in one of two ways, or by combining the two. You can conduct a formal testing program in which athletes perform technical and tactical skills and demonstrate aspects of physical conditioning relevant to your sport. Alternatively, you can have them play one or more practice games, and by observing and talking with your athletes, you can make a reasonably accurate rating. Or, as some coaches do, you can use a combination of formal and informal evaluations, formally

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testing athletes on technical skills and physical conditioning and informally evaluating their other competencies.

Step 3: Analyze Your Situation

In preparation for developing a season plan you need to collect information specific to your situation. Essentially, you're assessing what is available to you and what limitations you will have. To help you make this assessment, answer the questions in form 12.2 as completely as you can.

FORM 12.2

Evaluating Your Team Situation

- How many practices will you have over the entire season, and how long can practices be?
- How many contests will you have over the entire season?
- What special events (team meetings, parent orientation sessions, banquets, tournaments) will you have, and when?
- How many athletes will you be coaching? How many assistants will you have? What is the ratio of athletes to coaches?
- What facilities will be available for practice?
- What equipment will be available for practice?
- How much money do you have for travel and other expenses?
- What instructional resources (videos, books, charts) will you need?
- What other support personnel will be available?
- What other factors may affect your instruction plan?

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching,* 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024).

If your situation is less than ideal for instruction (e.g., a practice space that is too small, not enough equipment, or not enough assistants), obviously you should first seek to improve your situation. If you cannot, planning becomes even more critical so that you optimize the use of the resources available.

Step 4: Establish Priorities

Your next step is to establish clear priorities about which skills you will be able to teach and practice given your situation (e.g., time, equipment, facilities, or number of coaches and athletes). Evaluate the skills and systems you wish to teach based on two criteria:

1. *The importance or centrality of the skill to playing the sport.* Evaluate each skill by answering these questions:
    - What must be taught in the time available to achieve worthwhile outcomes?
    - What should be covered if good use is made of the time available?
    - What could be taught if time permits?

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2. *Your athletes' readiness to learn the skill.* Ask yourself these questions:
    - Do they have the strength, endurance, flexibility, and motor coordination to learn the skill?
    - Do they have the mental capacity to learn the skill?
    - Is there a skill they must learn (a prerequisite) before you can teach this skill?
    - Is it safe to teach the skill?

Step 5: Plan Practices

Introduction

Now, for the fun part—you get to design your coaching "classroom" each day for practice! Master coaches emphasize that the way you teach in practices is what contributes most to your success as a coach. One of the biggest mistakes coaches make is not putting enough time and thought into practice planning. Incredibly, you should spend about as much time planning and evaluating practices as you do in conducting the actual practices.

Don Showalter, 10-time USA Basketball gold medalist head coach emphasized the importance of practice planning (USA Basketball, 2019, para. 2):

> *For a practice session, I make sure I have everything covered, because just to wing it in practice will not make your team better. I try to make the next practice schedule immediately after practice the day before, while that practice is fresh. It generally takes me an hour or more to make the practice plan. I have always said that players do not have bad practices, but coaches do. Having a practice plan will make sure you don't have bad practices.*

Planning for Problems During the Season: The Premortem

High school cross country coach Randy Hisner used a method called a premortem (opposite of postmortem) in which his team members responded to the following fake headline Hisner had made up, "Braves Upset in Sectional, Fail to Defend Title" (Hisner, 2021). His 2016 team had been a pleasant surprise, winning the sectional easily with a very young team. Coach Hisner wanted his very talented 2017 team, which was expected to dominate, to not take anything for granted and to consider what could go wrong so that they could plan accordingly to make things go right.

He showed his athletes the headline to try to make the possibility of failure real. He wanted them to use their imaginations to look back from a hypothetical future to explain why their talented team fell short of their potential and expectations for a successful season title. Coach Hisner admitted that his athletes generated many potential problematic scenarios that he had not even considered, and the team brainstormed ways to prevent or solve each one. For example, injuries to key team members could occur, so the team committed to train all athletes, even junior varsity members, with the mindset that they are an integral

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Planning for Problems During the Season: The Premortem *(continued)*

part of the team and that they must prepare in case they are asked to step into the shoes of an injured starter.

The premortem approach worked because having to visualize and then problem-solve about "what did happen" is more powerful than just discussing "what could happen." Coach Hisner felt the manufactured headline and real sense of possible failure created a productive conversation to prepare for the season and not take anything for granted.

How Much Practice Is Optimal for Athletes?

Another mistake coaches make is to blindly buy in to the "more is better" mindset that has led to longer and longer practices for athletes. Although professional and elite athletes spend a significant portion of their lives training for their sports, is it truly our intent to make high school athletes train to the point where they must sacrifice their health and well-being just to play varsity soccer?

Although two practices per day at the beginning of preseasons may be necessary, the overuse of multiple practices in a day is likely to lead to burnout, injuries, and a lack of enjoyment and motivation for the sport. Similarly, there may be some days that early morning practices need to be scheduled, but to do so four days a week in July and August leading into your middle school volleyball season is inappropriate. Teenagers need at least eight hours of sleep per night (nine is actually better), and their internal clocks are not developmentally wired for early morning activities. For the most part, limit practices to no more than once a day, and carefully consider the costs and benefits of early morning practices for adolescents.

Coaches should consider the age and skill levels of athletes when determining the optimal length of a practice session. Many sport governing bodies (e.g., USA Football, USA Swimming) provide guidance for length of training sessions based on age. Our recommendations for number of weekly practices and practice lengths are provided in table 12.1. These are general recommendations and will vary by sport, and coaches should also consider their athletes' needs and time of season in determining practice length. For example, teams are often assigned practice blocks (e.g., 3:00 p.m. to 5:00 p.m.), but coaches should not design their practices just to fill the time block. Instead, they should design their practices to provide the highest quality and best use of time to teach and prepare athletes for where they are in the season. Preseason practices that involve more conditioning and learning are typically longer than later season practices that involve more fine-tuning and preparing for specific events and opponents.

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TABLE 12.1 Suggested Number of Weekly Practices and Practice Lengths

Athlete age	Number of practices per week	Length of practices
6 years and under	1 to 2 days	45 to 60 min
7 to 8 years	2 days	60 min
9 to 10 years	2 days	60 to 75 min
11 to 12 years	2 to 3 days	75 to 90 min
13 to 14 years	3 to 4 days	75 to 90 min
15 to 16 years	4 to 5 days	90 to 120 min
17 years and above	5 to 6 days	90 to 120 min

Adapted by permission from W. Gilbert, *Coaching Better Every Season* (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2017), 150.

Practice Tips From a Pro: Pete Carroll

Seattle Seahawks football coach Pete Carroll views practice as the time to gain a competitive advantage, stating, “Practice is performance for us. We want to be really sharp and really precise... We practice better than, sharper than, anyone else can practice this game” (Lemov, 2017, para. 3-4). He suggests paying attention to details to set the drills precisely so there is no wasted time. He wants his players to feel the urgency and to always be moving in practice.

Coach Carroll states that energy should be felt every day in practice. He believes it starts with him as the coach to intentionally set the high energy tone of being positive and fun. He has his players “tap in” every day by hitting the sign “I’m in” before heading to the field. This act affirms their focus and commitment to being fully there at practice each day (Koss, 2018).

Coach Carroll has a deliberate philosophy about how coaches should approach providing feedback to players (Lemov, 2017, para. 6):

> *[We] always talk about what we want to see, the desired outcome, not about what went wrong or what the mistake was. We have to be disciplined and always use our language to talk about the next thing you can do right. It’s always about what we want to happen, not about the other stuff.*

If anything is to be criticized, it should be effort, as Coach Carroll states that effort is everything. Most of us don’t coach professional athletes, so we might need to help our athletes understand the mistake or error in order to work toward what should be, but notice Coach Carroll’s focus on the positive, “what we want to happen.”

An essential theme in all of Coach Carroll’s practices is competition; he feels that competition is what elevates players’ involvement, focus, and energy. It helps to explain the importance and benefits of competition to your players. In Coach Carroll’s words, “Competition is about striving for what you want. It’s not about beating somebody down” (Koss, 2018). While not everyone coaches professional athletes, each of us can learn from

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Practice Tips From a Pro: Pete Carroll *(continued)*

(Koss, 2018). While not everyone coaches professional athletes, each of us can learn from some of Coach Carroll's practice strategies.

Using the Games Approach in Practices

Can you recall how adults taught you to play a sport? The coach or teacher probably taught you the basic technical skills using a series of drills that you likely found boring. As you began to learn the basic technical skills, the coach eventually taught you some of the tactical skills, and then finally, you were able to play the game. If you were like us, you became impatient during what seemed to be endless instruction and drills and very little playing of the game.

On the surface, what we call the traditional approach (playing the game only after practicing the basic technical and tactical skills) makes sense, but we've discovered that this approach has serious shortcomings. Today, we know more about the way young people learn, and this knowledge has led to the development of an alternative way to teach how to play the game. It's called the *games approach* (Mitchell et al., 2020). This approach teaches athletes how to play the game better and retains the joy of participation more commonly seen in sandlot play. In this chapter, we introduce you to the games approach to coaching.

Technical and Tactical Skills

To understand the games approach, you need to know what is meant when using the terms *technique* or *technical skills* and *tactics* or *tactical skills*.

Technical Skills

We use the terms *technique* and *technical skills* here to mean the specific procedures to move one's body to perform the task that needs to be accomplished (i.e., the "how to do it"). One procedure may be to move quickly to a particular space and then to gain control of and direct an object such as a ball, puck, or shuttle by trapping, kicking, catching, throwing, or hitting it. Another procedure may require controlling one's body to execute a prescribed movement such as in diving or a gymnastics routine. Or it may be to repeat a certain movement as efficiently as possible such as in running or rowing. Some sports require that athletes learn many technical skills, and others require that they learn only a few. The degree of difficulty of the technical skills can vary considerably both between and within sports.

Tactical Skills

Tactical skills are the decisions and actions of players in the contest to gain an advantage over the opposing team or players (i.e., the "when and where to do it"). A tactic can be as simple as hitting the ball to a player's weak side, placing the ball in the space away from

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the player, the give-and-go in basketball, or starting out fast in a race in the hope of tiring the opponent early. A player who demonstrates sound tactics knows where to go and how to use space and time intelligently, both alone and with teammates. We refer to such players as having good game sense, the ability to make tactical decisions within a game. (You can find ideas for sport-specific game-sense coaching online.)

In sport, we often use the terms *strategy* and *tactic* synonymously, but here onward, we use the term *strategy* to refer to a plan of action for your team for a season or series of contests. If you have a small but quick group of basketball players, you may decide that your strategy will be to press and fast break. If you have a big and powerful offensive line in football and a quarterback not so good at passing, you may decide to run the ball much more than you pass. Your strategy is a plan of action based on the talent of your team and what you expect will be the attributes of your competition to give you the best chance of success. In short, strategy is the big plan, and tactics are the plans within the game to gain an advantage.



Almost every sport requires successful execution of tactical skills.

Defining Skill

Skill has two meanings. It may mean a task—for example, we could say, "The skill of rifle shooting is underappreciated in the sport world." You could easily interchange the words task and skill in this sentence. *Skill* also may mean the quality of a person's performance at some task. When we say, "She demonstrates excellent shooting skill," we use the term skill to mean the *quality* of the shooter's performance.

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Technique and *skill* are two terms often used interchangeably, but they shouldn't be. Skill in sport is being able to execute the techniques required at the right time and place. The overall use of skill is different from the narrower use of technical and tactical skills. Remember that technical skills, or techniques, refer to the specific motor skills used to perform a task; tactical skills, or tactics, refer to the mental skills to know when and where to execute the technical skills. Skill, generally speaking, is the proficient use of techniques and tactics to play the sport (see the box Technical and Tactical Skills for an example).

We've all seen players who had superb technique but in contests, didn't know how to use that technique at the appropriate time or place. Sometimes when coaching using the traditional approach, we're unable to recognize when athletes lack tactical skills. Mistakenly, we become frustrated with such athletes, thinking that they either are choking in competition or that they need more practice on technical skills. We need to realize that we failed to teach them the tactical, or decision-making, skills they need in order to know when and where to use their technical skills.

As we go forward, keep in mind the difference between technique and skill and between strategy and tactic as we compare the traditional approach of coaching with the games approach.

Technical and Tactical Skills

Alejandro took up the sport of handball in graduate school, and after a couple of years, he was able to defeat the small group of players at his local gym. He decided to enter his first interstate tournament to see how he might fare. When he arrived for his first match, his opponent was warming up in the court. His opponent looked very fit, wore a very nice warm-up outfit, and repeatedly threw the ball against the back wall and hit nothing but kill shots against the front wall (that's good). His technique looked flawless to Alejandro.

As the game started, Alejandro's heart was racing, and he was worried that he might be humiliated. But early in the game, he realized that while his opponent had excellent technical skills, his opponent lacked tactical skills. The opponent didn't know who to position himself in the court, select the right shot for the situation, or adjust to the various tactics that Alejandro employed. Alejandro won the match easily.

Alejandro's opponent may have had superior technical skills, but Alejandro had better tactical skills. Of course, Alejandro needed to have sufficient technical skills to execute the tactics to play skillfully. Who do you think was the more skillful player?

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Traditional Approach

In the traditional approach to coaching, a typical practice session begins with a warm-up, followed by the teaching of a basic or advanced technical skill, which is followed by the repeated practice of this technical skill through one or more drills. This may be repeated for a variety of technical skills, and perhaps some instruction on tactical skills, which are also practiced through a series of drills. Next, the players play a practice game, or a scrimmage, during which the coach may or may not help the players see how the technical skill becomes part of the tactics of the game. The session concludes with some physical training if the practice session did not involve sufficient physical conditioning. Let's look at some of the potential shortcomings of this traditional approach.

Overemphasis on Technical Skills

Coaches tend to overemphasize the teaching and practicing of technical skills at the expense of teaching and practicing the decision-making skills needed to develop tactical skills. Drills to learn technical skills dominate practice time and often are structured to deemphasize any thinking or decision making by the athletes. Although properly structured drills can provide valuable learning in some aspects of skilled play, gamelike experiences are often more beneficial in developing both technical and tactical skills. These gamelike experiences help athletes respond less mechanistically and more creatively when spontaneous decisions and actions are needed in competition.

> *"Overcoaching is the worst thing you can do to a player."*
>
> DEAN SMITH

Overemphasis on Direct Instruction

Direct instruction—the coach telling the athlete how to perform the skill—is the dominant method used for teaching in the traditional approach. Although direct instruction is a useful way to teach some of what athletes need to learn, it is less suitable for the development of thinking skills required for problem solving and decision making in sport.

In contrast, the games approach relies more on indirect methods such as problem solving or guided discovery. These methods are better for developing thinking athletes because they involve athletes much more in the learning process and thus enable them to take greater responsibility for their learning. Research has demonstrated that the games approach enhanced decision making and overall game performance more so than the traditional approach (Gunes & Yilmaz, 2019; Mitchell et al., 2020).

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The Golden Thread

Great Britain Field Hockey uses the term the Golden Thread to emphasize that fun, gamelike activities are preferred in training sessions to constant use of technical drills (O'Sullivan, 2019). To keep this Golden Thread running through all practices, coaches are encouraged to include five elements in each session:

1. Lots of fun
2. Loads of (ball) touches
3. Playing on the edge of their comfort zones
4. Constant decision making
5. Gamelike drills or small-sided games

Think about your training sessions. Do you incorporate all of these elements? Remember the Golden Thread of gamelike activities that promote enjoyment, decision making, and competitive challenges for your athletes.

Mindless Drills

The traditional approach often teaches athletes the technical skills of the sport out of the context of the game. Athletes learn the basic skills through drills but find it difficult to apply these technical skills within the game because they don't practice them enough in gamelike situations. Athletes often do not automatically see the relevance of a drill and are unable to apply the learning from drills in the game setting, which hurts their performance.

The well-established principle of specificity says, *"Practice like you play, and you're more likely to play like you practiced."* In football, for example, players practice hitting two- and seven-person sleds. They run through tires and ropes and tackle large stuffed dummies. Do you think what is learned in these drills transfers to playing football? Is blocking a sled or a dummy anything like blocking an agile linebacker? Hardly. Could time be better spent practicing what players actually do in the game? Absolutely!

In baseball, players often swing weighted bats before hitting. The principle of specificity indicates that this is not a good idea. Another common practice in baseball is to have players hit 25 to 50 balls at a time during practice. This may be useful when the coach is trying to help the player master the hitting skill, but when preparing for a game, wouldn't it be better to take maybe three swings, step out to let someone else hit three, and then step back in? The practice would be better aligned with game conditions.

Basketball coaches often use drills to teach offensive patterns. Players learn stereotyped responses, often without any defensive resistance, whereas in real games the pressure of the defense and the action of the game call for much more flexible responses. It's one thing to learn a technical or tactical skill in a repetitive drill in which the decisions are minimized, and quite another thing to perform that skill in a game.

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Boredom

Another problem with the traditional approach's overreliance on nongamelike drills is that they are boring, sometimes because the athletes spend much of their time standing in lines and sometimes because the drills are just tediously repetitious. Drills also often eliminate or reduce the opportunities for players to problem-solve as they would in a real game. Part of the joy of sport is the intellectual challenge of making the right decisions to maximize the chances of winning—that is, to demonstrate good tactical skills.



In drills, athletes get bored standing in line instead of enjoying the challenge of making decisions in gamelike situations.

Many coaches believe that highly repetitive, monotonous drills are the only way to master technical skills, but that's not true. The games approach can make practice of technical skills much more enjoyable and relevant by making drills more gamelike and eliminating athletes standing in lines to take their turns.

How frequently have you heard athletes say that they loved playing the games but hated practice? The traditional approach to practicing takes much of the fun out of playing the sport. Overly structured practices using drills that have little direct relevance to playing the game diminish the playful element of participation and stifle players' motivation to play. Nevertheless, many players love the sport so much that they endure these practices in order to have the opportunity to play in real games. Others simply quit.

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Essence of the Games Approach

Are you doubtful that the games approach is a better way to coach than the traditional approach? Read this section with an open mind and then weigh the pros and cons of the two approaches. Or, perhaps you are interested in the games approach but find it overwhelming to consider how to coach this way. Don't worry: In this chapter, we explain how you can design practices using the games approach.

As the name implies, the games approach emphasizes learning the game through gamelike practice activities that create realistic and enjoyable learning situations. Athletes learn what to do as they play; this is called tactical awareness.

When your athletes understand the tactics they must use in the game, they are then eager to develop the technical skills that let them execute those tactics. Because your athletes are motivated to learn or refine their technical skills, they'll be more receptive to your instruction because you are teaching them what they want to learn and they are more willing to commit time to doing drills to practice technical skills. Research shows that athletes experienced more enjoyment and motivation when being coached using the games approach as opposed to traditional coaching (Gunes & Yilmaz, 2019; Pimenta & Light, 2018).

One of the common misconceptions about the games approach is that technical and tactical skills are learned exclusively through playing the sport or modified gamelike versions of the sport. That is not correct. In the traditional approach, practice begins and emphasizes technical skill development, sometimes followed by tactical skill training, and then playing the game. In the games approach, practice begins by playing carefully crafted versions of the game to develop both technical and tactical skills, followed by further practice of technical skills, often through drills, and then integrating these into more gamelike play. Another misconception of the games approach is that it reduces to playing a variety of games to simulate the actual sport with coaches correcting mistakes as these games are played. Read on to understand what the games approach is all about.

Holistic Approach

The games approach is a more holistic approach to learning the sport, focusing first on helping players understand what the game is all about, and then helping them learn how to play the game. Through this approach, players discover what to do in the game, not by you telling them, but by experiencing it themselves. What you do as an effective coach is help them understand what they've experienced.

With your guidance, for example, your athletes may discover that they need to master certain techniques to execute a particular tactic or that they need to be able to read the play to select the appropriate tactic. In contrast to the highly structured and coach-centered traditional approach, the games approach is an athlete-centered, guided

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discovery method of teaching. It empowers your athletes to solve the problems that arise in the game, and that's a big part of the fun of playing a sport.

For example, a tactical challenge in basketball is for the team to maintain possession of the ball on offense. Players maintain possession by selecting and executing passing, dribbling, and moving to get open and balance the court. In a games approach, players are placed in a game-like situation that emphasizes possession before they practice solutions such as passing, dribbling, and cutting (moving without the ball).

How the Games Approach Works

The games approach is based on practice being as closely aligned as possible with what actually occurs in games, but it is not simply a throw-out-the-ball-and-let-them-play approach. It's an approach that requires a coach's skillful analysis of the game to structure gamelike situations so that players learn what they need to know to play well. Coaches do this using three methods:

1. Shaping play
2. Focusing play
3. Enhancing play

We next describe these coaching tools using team sports as examples, but they can be applied to individual sports as well.

Shaping Play

Shaping the play of your athletes is about *teaching through the game.* Here are four aspects of the game that you can change to create a variety of learning situations:

1. The rules define what players can and cannot do in a game. You can change the rules in practice to create the learning environment you want.
2. You can alter the number of players to increase player participation and active learning time. Examples are games such as two-on-two basketball and three-on-three soccer. The advantage of using these games is that they increase the opportunity to learn technical and tactical skills in a microcosm of the full game. You can also create imbalances between the number of offensive and defensive players to simulate certain game situations. The fast-break drill in basketball in which two offensive players attempt to score against one defensive player is a common example.
3. You can alter the size of the playing area or change the size of the goal to help players focus on learning a particular aspect of the game. For example, in soccer, you could have three attackers against one defender practicing in a 15-by-15-meter grid, which would allow the attackers time to develop their passing skills. Gradually you could reduce the space, making it more difficult for the attackers because the defender can cover the space more easily.
4. You can shape play by modifying the goal and the scoring.

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Other ways of shaping play include modifying the playing equipment, controlling the actions of the better players who may tend to dominate the game, and manipulating playing time. The key to shaping play is to redesign the game so that your athletes have the opportunity to practice what is relevant in the real game.

Focusing Play

Of course you don't just shape play by modifying the variables described earlier and hoping the athletes will teach themselves the techniques, tactics, and decision-making skills they need to learn. Nor will athletes always fully understand the similarities and differences between the practice game and the real game. As they play, you'll need to focus your players' attention on the key elements of the game that you want them to learn. When you watch master coaches at work, they excel at focusing their players on the critical elements of the game as they practice. This vital process determines the quality of practice and helps players transfer what they are learning in practice games to real games.

Focusing can be done by explaining the purpose of the practice game and labeling the key elements to be learned, and then during play, reminding players of these actions. You can also stop the play and correct the incorrect action or positively reinforce the correct action.

Questioning is a primary tool that games-approach coaches use to help players recognize what they need to learn. Part of the art of coaching is knowing when to use questions and when to provide answers. Generally, when athletes are learning something new and don't have the knowledge, you need to provide the answers. When they likely know but are not focused on what they should be, questions are a good way to direct their attention; for example, "Where in our offense are we most vulnerable to a double-team trap" and "What can you do when you see a double team coming at you?"

A more elaborate focusing technique is called the freeze replay. The coach gives an agreed-on signal to "freeze" the players, who must immediately stop. Play is then rewound back to the critical point and then, through questioning, the coach helps the players replay the situation to draw out the key elements of good play. For example, "Stop! Everyone freeze. Look at where you are and our spacing in relation to the defense. What do you notice?" The freeze replay, when skillfully used, is a great tool for capturing those teachable moments and provides opportunities for players to think about their actions.

Enhancing Play

Presenting challenges during practices, using handicapping techniques to make close contests, and encouraging players and recognizing them for the progress they make are all ways to enhance play. Your personality and knowledge of the game, and the respect players have for you, are also important factors that help enhance play.

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Advantages of the Games Approach

The games approach to coaching gives you a huge advantage in motivating your athletes because practices are much more gamelike and thus much more enjoyable. Moreover, your players will quickly recognize that in the games approach, the practice is focused on helping them, whereas in the traditional approach, it often seems that practice is focused on obeying the coach's commands. In other words, practices using the games approach are athlete centered rather than coach centered.



Freeze replay captures teachable moments.

Coach-Defined Success in Basketball Offense

Former college basketball coach Dean Smith (Smith & Bell, 2004) used a unique scoring system in practice scrimmages to enhance the shot selection of his players. A good shot to Smith was one that the shooter could make most of the time that was taken with rebounders in position, unless it was an open layup.

A great shot (e.g., layup) was worth three points (even if it didn't go in), a good shot was worth two points (even if it didn't go in), and a shot that was merely acceptable (e.g., shot clock winding down) was worth one point, even if it didn't go in. Bad shots, even those that were made but that shouldn't have been taken, were worth zero points. Loss of the ball without getting a shot was minus two points. Coach Smith gave all the scores to a manager, and the winning team was announced at the end of the scrimmage. Consider how you could define success to enhance the play of your team.

Evaluating the Games Approach

The games approach is consistent with the coaching philosophy advocated in part I of the book. Once you fully understand the games approach, you'll quickly see its advantages.

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Your athletes not only will learn and play the game better but also enjoy the sport much more; as a result you'll have far fewer discipline problems.

See table 9.1 for a comparison of the games approach and the traditional approach. If you'd like to understand the games approach better, numerous resources are available online, and we also recommend the following books:

- *Play Practice: Engaging and Developing Skilled Players From Beginner to Elite* by Launder and Piltz (2013)
- *Teaching Sport Concepts and Skills: A Tactical Games Approach for Ages 7 to 18* by Mitchell, Oslin, and Griffin (2020)

TABLE 9.1 Traditional Approach Compared With the Games Approach

Traditional approach	Games approach
Uses drills primarily to practice technical skills	Uses drills that are closely aligned with the game to teach technical and tactical skills
Teaches the specific elements of the game and then combines them into the whole	Teaches the whole game and then refines the parts
Coach centered (the coach uses direct instructional methods that may or may not consider the athletes' needs)	Athlete centered (the coach creates a learning environment that focuses on the athletes' needs using a variety of teaching methods)
Practices are often boring and thus unmotivating to athletes	Practices are fun, relevant, and challenging and thus increase motivation
Greatly increases athletes' dependence on the coach	Develops increasing independence of athletes from the coach by being actively involved in the learning process
Extensive drilling to make athletes strive to develop automatic responses that may promote mindlessness when playing	Practices designed to develop the thinking, understanding, and decision-making skills that are required to play well
Athlete input virtually nonexistent; coach makes most or all of the decisions	Considerable athlete input; collaborative decision making with athletes and coach
Athletes not encouraged to help each other master the skills of the sport	Athletes encouraged to help each other master the skills of the sport
Preferred approach of command-style coaches	Preferred approach of cooperative-style coaches

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Coaches who are master teachers do far more than just present the technical and tactical skills of the sport—they provide their athletes with real understanding about those skills. They help them understand how each technique and tactic fits into the way the sport is played. They strive to provide them with insight so they can make intelligent decisions about how to perform, and they encourage self-reflection. With better understanding and increased autonomy, athletes are able to take greater responsibility for their own learning.

One caution about coaching using the games approach: Early practices may seem a bit chaotic to you, the players, and those watching, especially parents. During gamelike practices, the players are gaining experience in understanding the game (game sense) and learning which technical skills are needed to execute tactical skills. During this early phase, players coached via the traditional approach typically develop technical skills more quickly than players coached via the games approach. Players coached via the games approach, however, gradually catch up in technical skills to players coached via the traditional approach and exceed them in game sense (Vickers, 2007).

As you prepare for your next season of coaching, reflect on your practices and ask yourself whether adopting the games approach may improve your coaching. Review the drills you use to see how closely they align with what your players do in games. Think about the range of skills required to play your sport and consider how much time you spend on developing each of them.

Adopt the games approach in whole or in part by trying some of these ideas:

- Begin practice with a game.
- Redesign some of your drills to make them more gamelike.
- Study your sport more to identify the tactical principles of the sport and then design a series of drills to help athletes grasp these principles.
- Try a freeze replay and ask a question rather than give the answer.
- Build in time for your athletes to reflect on their actions during the practice.

Dial Up Your Practice Representativeness

The more practice represents competitive situations, the more likely it is that athletes' skills will transfer successfully to competition itself (O'Sullivan, 2019). This is called representativeness, or how much practice tasks simulate (or represent) key aspects of the competitive environment.

Here's a great way to consider how representative your practice activities are (Renshaw et al., 2019). Think about how each activity would rate on a scale of 1 (low representativeness) to 10 (high representativeness). Spiking a volleyball against the wall might be a 1, whereas going up for a spike against excellent blockers and a solid defense might be a 10. Most of your practice drills will fall somewhere in between.

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Dial Up Your Practice Representativeness *(continued)*

Ask yourself how to dial up the representativeness of practice activities. If something starts at a two, how can you structure it to increase to a four or five? Look at your practice plans and rate your activities in terms of how much they represent the competitive demands. Consider how you can dial drills up to higher levels. Dialing up your practice representativeness will ensure better transfer of skills and tactics into competition.

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